

FIELD OF VISION | SHARDA UGRA

Batting for Order

On the surface, Virender Sehwag and George Jacques Danton belong to disparate worlds. But the fiery French revolutionary and the cricketer from Najafgarh are curiously united. All through his career Sehwag has batted as if Danton's famous call to arms rings in his ears: "Audacity, more audacity, always audacity".

Even without a bat in his hand these days, Sehwag is still being audacious. He has issued an ultimatum to the Delhi & Districts Cricket Association (DDCA) to either revamp its selection structure or lose his services as a player. The DDCA responded with typical finesse. Some called it an empty threat. Others accused Sehwag of being bought over by Haryana for a plot of land. Or throwing a sulk because his cousin got dropped from the Ranji team. Suspect Sehwag's motives all you like, but listen to his message. Superstar cricketers usually tend not to pick fights in public.

That Delhi's selection was ridden with corruption and nepotism is well-known. DDCA's vices are regularly exposed in the city's newspapers, every incident marked by exposure, furore and a quiet demise, give or take some minor shuffling of deck-chairs.

India is listening this time because the capital's greatest ever player told *Mail Today* that its cricket selection is ridden with "interference" and "manipulation". That a ten-man sports committee made up of a wholesaler of spectacle frames, a contractor and PSU employees, among others, enjoys untrammelled power over selectors. It leans on them to pick candidates, either family members or someone they owed favours to.

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Today, this system has corroded Delhi cricket's supply chain completely. At the junior level, every possible rival to sports committee candidates is simply not picked in case he outshines Rinku Rishtedaar or Sonu Sifarishi.

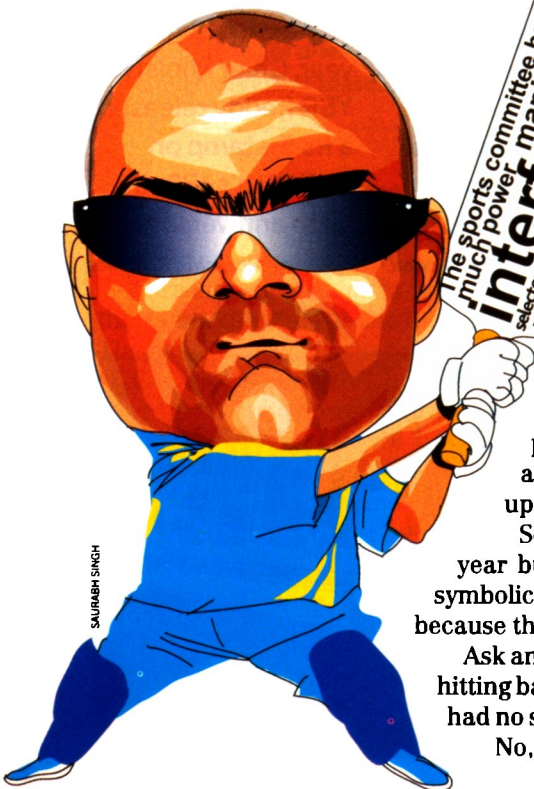
Insiders say Sehwag has been unhappy for several years now. He attended a few DDCA sports committee meetings and found his suggestions around the game cast aside. He is said to be determined to follow through on his plan: he will meet with DDCA President Arun Jaitley and General Secretary Sneha Bansal and present them with his ideas for change. If they are not well-received or acted upon, he will pick up his NOC and leave.

Sehwag may not play many games for Delhi every year but the impact of his departure will be heavily symbolic. It is important that he succeed in some way because the situation in the DDCA is now beyond tenable.

Ask any Delhi cricketer this question: suppose a hard-hitting batsman came through from Najafgarh today but had no sports committee godfather? Could he make it?

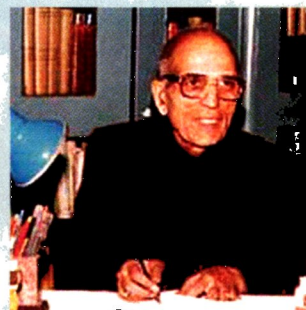
No, they say in one voice, no bloody way.

The sports committee has too much power, manipulation interference selectors get together and vote for their players I have talked to all the top officials



AWARDED: Posthumously to **Major Mohit Sharma** of 1 Para (SF), the Ashok Chakra, the nation's highest peacetime gallantry award. The second Ashok Chakra was awarded to **Major D. Sreeram Kumar** of the 39 Assam Rifles in Manipur.

CONFERRED: On Sanskrit poet **Saty Vrat Shastri** the Jnanpith Award for his contributions to the enrichment of the language.



He became the first Sanskrit poet to get the award since its inception.

DIED: **Mawlana Jamil Ahmed Ilyasi**, 76, president of the All India Organisation of Imams. He represented five lakh imams in India.

DIED: **Kartar Devi**, 66, minister of state in the Congress Government in Haryana. She held five portfolios before her health failed.

DIED: **Sheenandan Jha**, socialist leader and former Bihar science and technology minister. He had represented Jhaja Assembly seat five times. He was 90.